



ENVOYS: Saran (left); Sen secretary Kanwal Sibal, who recently finished his term as India's ambassador to Russia.

Sources claim that while the foreign service would want it to go to someone from IFS—the name of India's envoy to Pakistan, Satyabrata Pal, is in circulation—External Affairs Minister Pranab Mukherjee is in favour of sending a heavyweight political appointee to Washington, even one of the ministers. But not many are enthused.

With India's current strategic honeymoon with Washington and bilateral relationships on the upswing, the job acquires greater importance. As there is a change of guard in Washington, India would do well to ensure that its new ambassador hits the ground running and adds to the momentum in the Indo-US ties.

by Saurabh Shukla

Vacancy in Washington

DELHI The office of the Indian ambassador to the US may be one of the most important diplomatic jobs in town, but surprisingly there are few takers for it in the political establishment. A search is underway as the extension given to the present envoy

Ronen Sen ends on March 31. Sen, a retired 1966 batch IFS officer, who once served in Rajiv Gandhi's office, was rewarded with the prized Washington posting after the UPA came to power in 2004.

Insiders say amongst the names doing the

rounds are that of former foreign secretary Shyam Saran, currently a special envoy to the prime minister, who enjoys the confidence of Manmohan Singh. Saran was a key negotiator on the Indo-US nuclear deal. Also in the running is former foreign

THE BUZZ OF THE WEEK

The Congress is trying hard to postpone the Karnataka polls saying that the delimitation exercise will take time. The BJP, eager to cash in on its electoral successes, wants early polls. A fracas over the issue is gathering steam.

VOICES

“The more bitterly the Leftists criticise the Central Government in media, the more warmly they are hand in hand insidiously.”

Rajnath Singh, BJP president

“BJP is dealing with the insecurities of the prime minister-in-waiting, who has waited for decades and is destined to wait for eternity.”

Abhishek Singhvi, Congress spokesperson

“Pranab Mukherjee is CPI(M)'s spokesman in West Bengal. In Delhi he plays to the tune of the Congress leadership. Political consideration got him the Padma Vibhushan.”

Mamata Banerjee, Trinamool Congress chief

“Godhra certainly helped (Narendra) Modi. He cannot forget Godhra. Its victims and the Gujarat riots were certainly very useful for him.”

Bal Thackeray, Shiv Sena supremo

“It was an enjoyable series, a hard-fought contest over the last one month. India played some very good cricket and proved that they are the number two team in the world.”

Ricky Ponting, Australian cricket captain